TO MY CURRENT SELF

1. Perspectives of Self

How do you personally define yourself? What makes you who you are?

According to William James, in his book *The Principles of Psychology*, the self consists of two separate but interconnected aspects: the "I" and the "Me." The "I" refers to the self that experiences, reflects, and makes sense of one's past, present, and future. Meanwhile, the "Me" refers to the self that is shaped and understood through interactions with other people and the different social environments one belongs to.

Relating this concept to my own life, I would describe myself as someone who will always try to make things possible, even when circumstances seem unfavorable. I have always tried to look at the brighter side of every situation, believing that there is always a way forward, no matter how difficult things may become. I also consider myself an adaptable person. I can adjust to different situations and connect with people regardless of their personalities or backgrounds. In many ways, I find myself going along with the wavelength of those around me.

Looking at William James' concept, I believe that my "I" is reflected in my optimism and my willingness to keep going despite uncertainties. On the other hand, my "Me" is reflected in how my interactions with my family, friends, and the people I encounter have influenced the way I think and behave. I have come to realize that I am not simply a person with a fixed set of characteristics. Rather, I am someone whose understanding of himself continues to develop through personal experiences and relationships. In a way, the person I am today is a combination of what I believe about myself and what I have learned from the people who have become part of my life.

2. Biological Influences

How have your genes, family background, and physical characteristics influenced you?

I genuinely believe that one of the major factors that shaped me into who I am today is my biological background. Growing up, I was surrounded by my parents, whose caring attitudes taught me the importance of compassion, and my sisters, whose problem-solving abilities have influenced how I approach different situations. In one way or another, I believe that some of the qualities I possess have been influenced by the people I grew up with.

However, I also recognize that biology alone cannot explain who I am. As discussed in our module, the self is not solely determined by nature but is also continuously shaped by nurture and experiences. The environment I grew up in, the people I met, and the challenges I

encountered all contributed to the development of my character. This made me realize that although I may have inherited certain characteristics, how I choose to develop and express them is also influenced by my experiences. Ultimately, I am a product of both my biological foundation and the environment that continues to shape me.

3. Body Image

How do you perceive your physical appearance? Are you confident about your body?

I may not be the tallest person, nor do I consider myself the most handsome, but I am genuinely thankful for the body I have been given. There are moments when I wish I were a little taller or that certain aspects of my appearance were different. However, as I grow older, I have gradually learned to appreciate myself beyond the physical characteristics I sometimes wish I could change.

One thing I learned from our discussion about body image is that the way we perceive ourselves is not entirely independent of our surroundings. Our body image can be influenced by social expectations, cultural standards of beauty, and how we think other people see us. Looking back, I realize how fortunate I am to have grown up surrounded by family and friends who never made me feel that I needed to change my appearance to deserve their acceptance.

Because of this, I have learned that although I cannot always change my physical characteristics, I can change the way I perceive and carry myself. I am slowly understanding that confidence does not necessarily mean being completely satisfied with every aspect of my appearance. Sometimes, it simply means accepting that I am not perfect and choosing to appreciate myself anyway. For me, having people who love and accept me for who I am has been one of the greatest gifts, because their acceptance has also helped me learn to accept myself.

4. Personality

What are your personality traits? How do you behave and interact with others?

I would describe myself as an extroverted person, which is also reflected in the results of the personality test we took during class. I enjoy being around people, starting conversations, and creating an environment where others feel comfortable. I have always loved being the bundle of joy for those around me, and I find happiness in knowing that I can make someone's day a little better.

Our discussion of Gordon Allport's definition of personality helped me understand that personality is a dynamic organization of psychological and physical characteristics that influence our patterns of behavior, thoughts, and feelings. Relating this to myself, I believe that my extroversion and adaptability are among the characteristics that consistently influence how I interact with others.

However, I also recognize that a personality test cannot completely capture who I am. Although it can provide an idea of my dominant traits, there are still many aspects of myself that cannot simply be measured through a set of questions. I may be naturally outgoing, but I also have moments when I prefer to be alone, reflect, and process my thoughts. This made me realize that personality is not simply about assigning labels to ourselves. It is also about understanding the different ways we respond to people, situations, and experiences.

5. Identity Development

How has your identity changed from childhood to your current age?

When I was still a child, my biggest concerns were whether I would be allowed to play outside and how I could convince my mother not to make me take an afternoon nap. Life seemed much simpler back then. I rarely thought about the future, responsibilities, or the kind of person I wanted to become.

Now that I have turned 20, I realize how much things have changed. There are responsibilities I need to fulfill, decisions I have to make, and expectations that sometimes make me question whether I am doing enough. I can say that I have developed a stronger sense of conviction. When I genuinely believe in something, I am now more willing to stand up for it and fight for what I think is right.

However, despite these changes, I still feel that I have not completely established my identity. There are moments when I find myself questioning what I truly want, where I want to go, and what kind of person I eventually want to become. I sometimes feel that I am still figuring things out, and I cannot confidently pinpoint exactly who I am.

Through our discussions on selfhood, I realized that this uncertainty is not necessarily a sign that I lack an identity. Rather, it may be part of the process of constructing one. The self is not something that is established once and remains unchanged forever. It continues to develop as we encounter new experiences, meet different people, and gain a better understanding of ourselves. Perhaps, at 20, I am not supposed to have everything figured out just yet. I am still growing, and I am learning to embrace that process.

6. Culture and Ethnicity

How have your family, Filipino culture, traditions, and environment shaped you?

My family has played a significant role in shaping the person I am today. I have always believed that family is our first teacher, our first guide, and the foundation that helps us navigate the world. Looking back, I realize how much of what I practice and believe today can be traced back to the values my family instilled in me. They taught me how to distinguish right from wrong, how to treat other people, and how to face different situations in life.

Aside from my family, Filipino culture has also contributed to the way I understand myself and the world around me. Growing up in a culture that values resilience, resourcefulness, and pakikipagkapwa has influenced how I respond to challenges and interact with others. I have learned to adapt when circumstances do not go as planned, find solutions when resources are limited, and recognize the importance of maintaining meaningful relationships with the people around me.

This connects to our discussion in Module 3 about how culture is internalized through socialization and becomes part of our attitudes, beliefs, and behavior. I realized that many of the things I consider natural about myself are actually values and practices I learned from my family and the society I grew up in. In this sense, my identity is not formed independently. It is also a reflection of the culture, traditions, and people that have surrounded me throughout my life.

7. The Self in the Age of AI

How does technology and social media influence how you see yourself?

With the growing prevalence of artificial intelligence, technology has gradually become integrated into almost every aspect of our daily lives. Personally, I can say that it has brought both convenience and challenges to my life. On the positive side, AI has made my academic responsibilities more manageable, especially when I need help understanding unfamiliar concepts, organizing my thoughts, or exploring different ideas. There are also moments when I find it easier to express my thoughts through AI when I simply need an avenue to process what I am feeling.

However, I also recognize that there are times when I become too dependent on it, to the point that I sometimes struggle to think through things independently. This made me realize that although technology can assist me, it should never replace my ability to think critically, make decisions, and form my own understanding of the world.

Connecting this to our discussions about the self as something shaped by social interactions and external influences, I realized that technology has also become part of the environment in which I construct my identity. What I consume online, the opinions I encounter, and the way I present myself on social media can influence how I perceive myself and others. This is why I believe it is important to remain mindful of how I use technology. I want to take advantage of what it can offer without allowing it to dictate how I think, feel, or define myself.

8. Mental Health and Wellbeing

How do you handle stress, emotions, challenges, and personal struggles?

I believe that mental health and wellbeing are just as important as our physical health. One of the ways I manage stress and overwhelming thoughts is by going outside for a walk. There is something peaceful about reconnecting with nature. Whenever I find myself overwhelmed by

academic responsibilities or personal concerns, taking a walk gives me the opportunity to pause, breathe, and temporarily distance myself from everything that occupies my mind.

I particularly enjoy the feeling of being surrounded by nature because it reminds me of how small I am in the grand scheme of things. Sometimes, I look at the vastness of the sky or the surroundings and realize that the problems I am facing, no matter how overwhelming they may seem at the moment, are only a small part of my entire life. It gives me comfort to remember that things change, difficult situations eventually pass, and I do not have to figure everything out all at once.

I think this also reflects my optimistic personality and the way I have learned to cope with challenges. Rather than allowing my worries to consume me, I try to give myself time to process them and regain perspective. I am still learning how to take better care of my mental and emotional wellbeing, but one thing I have come to understand is that taking a step back does not mean giving up. Sometimes, it simply means giving myself the space I need to continue moving forward.

Reflections Based on the Interviews

Based on the interviews, I realized that others see me as someone who is strong-willed, dependable, and determined. They described me as a person who stands by my words and does my best to fulfill my commitments. They also see me as someone who is approachable, helpful, and understanding, especially toward the people who matter to me. I was also reminded that I do not have to prove myself to others because my character is already reflected in how I treat and interact with them.

However, I also became aware of some aspects of myself that I still need to improve. I can sometimes be impatient and expect others to give the same effort that I give them. I also tend to become a crammer, which shows that I need to work on managing my time better. Another thing I learned is that I should become more open to other people's perspectives instead of always relying on what I already have in mind. I also need to understand that people have different ways of thinking and showing their care.

What stood out to me the most was how both interviewees recognized my growth over the years. From being someone who was not always open to suggestions, I have gradually learned to listen, understand, and consider other people's opinions. They also noticed how I have become more accepting of myself and more capable of learning from my mistakes.

Lastly, I realized that one of the qualities that makes me unique is how I handle challenges. Although I may appear strong and independent to others, they also recognize that I experience struggles of my own. What matters is that I continue to find ways to stand up, cope, and try again, even when things are difficult. Their responses reminded me that personal growth is not about being perfect, but about recognizing my weaknesses, appreciating my strengths, and continuously working to become a better version of myself.

MY PERSONAL MANIFESTO

A Promise to the Person I Am Becoming

I believe that life is a continuous process of learning, growing, and discovering who I truly am. I may not have everything figured out, but I choose to embrace every experience as an opportunity to understand myself better. I will not allow my mistakes to define me, but I will allow the lessons I gain from them to shape the person I become.

I promise to remain true to my values and stand firm in what I believe is right. I will strive to be a person whose words are reflected in actions, someone who can be trusted, approached, and counted on. I will continue to treat others with kindness and understanding, knowing that everyone carries struggles that may not always be visible.

I will also remind myself that not everyone thinks, feels, or gives in the same way I do. I will learn to manage my expectations, become more patient, and understand that genuine relationships are not measured by how much people can give in return. I will listen more, remain open to different perspectives, and recognize that there is always something I can learn from others.

I will take responsibility for my own growth. I will work on my weaknesses, especially my tendency to procrastinate and my difficulty managing time. I will learn to balance independence with the willingness to ask for help, and determination with the patience to understand that not everything happens according to my plans.

I promise to take care of myself, not only physically but also mentally and emotionally. I will allow myself to rest without feeling guilty, acknowledge my struggles without pretending to be strong all the time, and appreciate the little things that bring me peace. I will never measure my worth solely through achievements, appearances, or the expectations of others.

Above all, I will remain resilient. Like a tree that stands through changing seasons and strong winds, I will continue to stand firm even when life becomes difficult. I may bend, stumble, or lose my way, but I will always find the courage to begin again.

I do not promise to become a perfect person. I promise to become a better one, one decision, one lesson, and one day at a time.

MY HEALTH MANIFESTO

A Commitment to Taking Care of Myself

I believe that taking care of myself is not a luxury, but a responsibility. Health is not simply about being physically fit or free from illness. It is also about having peace of mind, understanding my emotions, and finding balance in the different aspects of my life.

I promise to listen to my body and give it the rest and nourishment it deserves. I will make an effort to develop healthier habits, stay physically active, eat properly, and get enough sleep. I understand that I do not have to make drastic changes overnight. Small, consistent efforts can make a meaningful difference.

I will also prioritize my mental and emotional well-being. I will allow myself to feel, acknowledge my struggles, and accept that I do not always have to be strong. Whenever life becomes overwhelming, I will take a step back, breathe, and give myself time to recover. I will not measure my worth through productivity alone.

I will make time for the things that bring me peace, whether it is taking a walk, enjoying nature, spending time with my family, or simply having a quiet moment with myself. I will learn to balance my responsibilities with the need to rest and enjoy life.

Lastly, I promise to be patient with myself. There will be days when I fail to follow my routines or fall back into unhealthy habits, but I will not let these moments discourage me. Instead, I will learn from them and try again.

I choose to take care of myself not because I need to become perfect, but because I deserve to live a life where I am healthy, fulfilled, and at peace.